1.4 Opposition to Immigration

Some people feel afraid when they face something new or unfamiliar. Their fear may make them lash out toward others. In the mid-1800s, some Americans reacted negatively to the arrival of new immigrants.

MAIN IDEA Some native-born Americans tried to restrict immigrants' rights because they feared change and worried about the financial impact of immigration.

FEAR AND JUDGMENT

The numbers of immigrants coming to the United States alarmed some native-born Americans, or Americans who were born in the United States. They feared that the influence of new languages, different religious practices, and new cultural traditions might change the culture of the United States. Their fears inspired many **prejudices**, or broad judgments about groups of people that are not based on reason or fact.

Because many immigrants accepted jobs for very little pay, some native-born Americans believed their own wages would be reduced as a result. Newspaper articles reporting the failed rebellions in Germany gave some Americans the impression that immigrants would try to inspire revolution in the United States. They also worried that local governments would increase taxes and strain public services in order to care for so many poor immigrants. As one American writer put it, "They increase our taxes, eat our bread, and encumber [clog] our streets."

Some elected officials proposed passing **nativist** laws, or laws that favored native-born Americans over immigrants, often focusing on religion. Most native-born Americans were Protestant. Some Protestants formed prejudices against Catholic immigrants entering the country—especially the Irish. Protestants feared that Catholics held an allegiance to a foreign power because the leader of their church, the Pope, reigned over the Catholic Church from Italy. At times, violence erupted between Protestants and Catholics. Anti-Catholic mobs burned a convent, or a dwelling for nuns, near Boston in 1834. Prejudice against Catholics also influenced immigration laws.

EXCLUDING IMMIGRANTS

During the 1840s, nativists organized groups to oppose immigration. One of these groups called itself the American Party. Its leaders told new members to say "I know nothing" if anyone asked what the party did, so people began calling the American Party the **Know-Nothing party**. The party proposed laws that prevented immigrants, especially Irish Catholics, from voting and holding public office. They also wanted to require immigrants to live in the country for 21 years before they could become citizens.

Membership in the party continued to grow. In 1855, 43 members of Congress belonged to the Know-Nothing party. But Congress refused to pass most of the party's proposed legislation, and party members' involvement in violence and corruption in various states made the party increasingly unpopular. By 1860, differing views on slavery broke up the party, but that was not the end of nativist ideas in the United States.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What issues increased American prejudice toward immigrants in the mid-1800s?
2. **ANALYZE VISUALS** In which different ways do these two political cartoons portray immigrants, native-born Americans, and the political process?
3. **EVALUATE** What role did religion play in nativist prejudices?

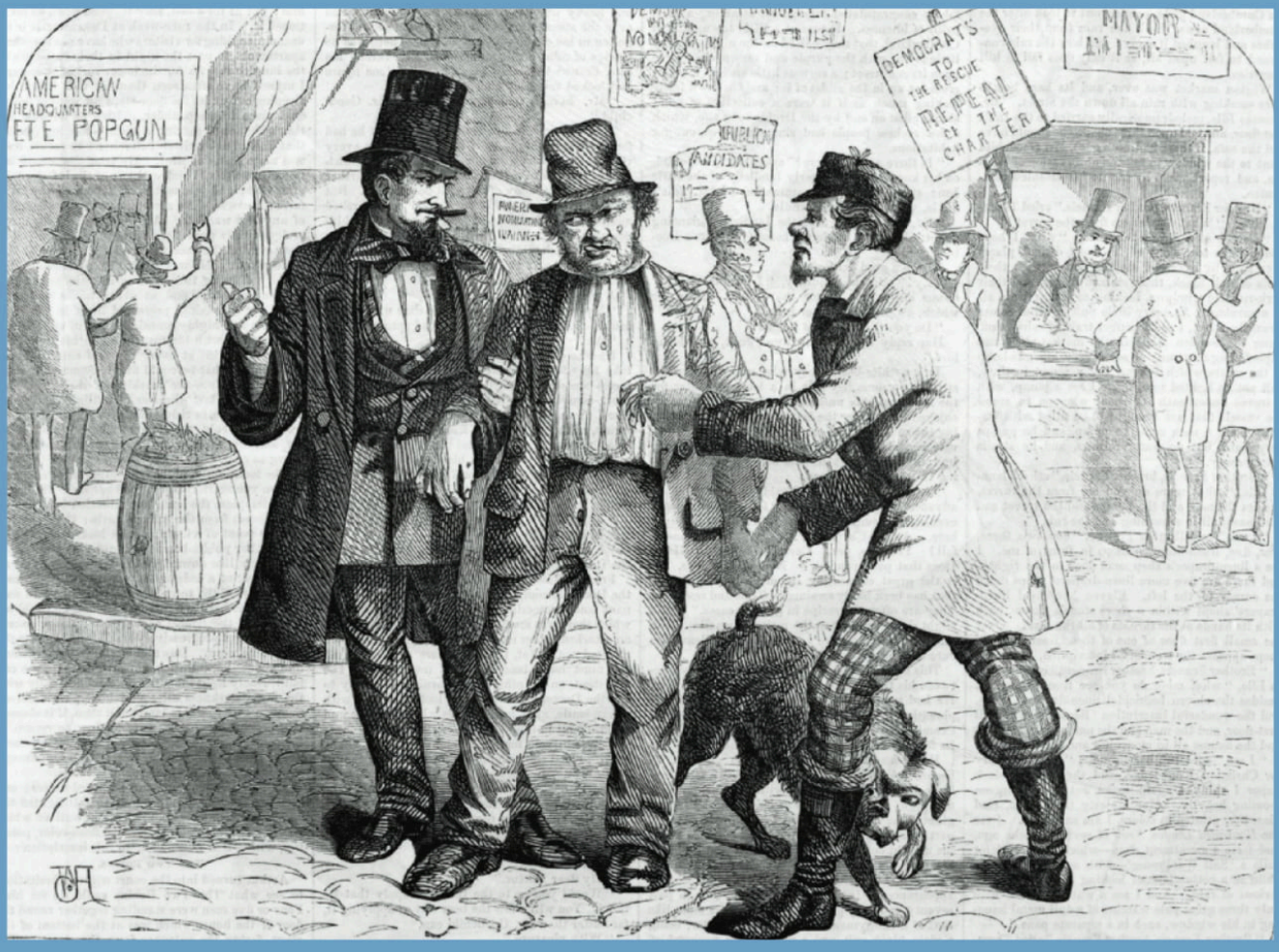
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CRITICAL VIEWING

These two cartoons from the 1850s reflect nativist attitudes toward immigrants. The first cartoon, published in a Know-Nothing newspaper, portrays an Irish and a German immigrant running away from a voting site with the ballot box, which they have stolen in the midst of a brawl. They are "clothed" in barrels that held whiskey and beer.

The second cartoon, from *Harper's Weekly*, shows a voter being pulled in two directions. On the left, a nativist politician attempts to persuade the voter. On the right, an Irish politician tries to do the same. What different characterizations of immigrant voters are shown in these cartoons?





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